Leakage-Aware Demand Forecasting

ML | Implementation and interview guide

Purpose and intended demonstration

Forecast one step ahead using lag features and expanding-window backtesting.

How the implementation works

Construct fourteen historical lags and weekday sine/cosine features. Ridge regression uses centered training design matrices and solves a regularized linear system. Evaluate each fold using only earlier observations.

Evaluation and evidence

Select regularization on earlier chronological folds; reserve the last 80 days as a final rolling one-step test. Compare seasonal-naive predictions from seven days earlier.

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Setup and commands

Requires Python 3.10 or newer and NumPy. Create a virtual environment: python -m venv .venv. On Windows use .venv\Scripts\python.exe if activation is unavailable. Install with python -m pip install -r requirements.txt. Run python app.py, then open results/report.html in your browser. Run python -m unittest discover -v to execute tests. The default seed is 42; change it with --seed. Replace sample_input.json using --input path-to-file.json, preserving its schema. Algorithm-only projects generate synthetic arrays from the seed rather than consuming external files.

Architecture and file responsibilities

CLI arguments -> JSON input or seeded generator -> domain pipeline -> validation or evaluation -> JSON and HTML artifacts. Imported functions can be used in a notebook or a separate application. Model checkpoints preserve learned arrays where applicable; see app.py for parameter order. This package does not include a production web service. Each project is independent and includes its own helper code so the ZIP can be extracted and run alone. app.py holds the experiment and domain functions: design, fit, run. kit.py contains reporting, input loading and only the retrieval or generation helpers needed by this project. sample_input.json contains editable inputs. test_app.py checks domain behaviors; test_reporting.py checks metrics and HTML output boundaries. results/metrics.json records outputs and results/report.html provides a browser-readable report. Numeric projects also save arrays or learned parameters to results/artifacts.npz; inspect its keys with numpy.load. MODEL_CARD.md explains intended use and limits. .github/workflows/tests.yml runs tests and the fixture experiment. No API key is needed.

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Limitations and next improvements

Every test prediction may use previously observed test values, which is valid for rolling one-step forecasts, not an 80-step open-loop forecast. The series is synthetic. Add real demand data, horizon-specific evaluation, holidays, prediction intervals and an explicit multi-step forecasting mode.

Interview walkthrough

Present the problem and demonstrate one normal example, then one failure or boundary case. Explain the baseline or fixture mode, the split or validation design, and one limitation before discussing an extension. Be ready to trace data through the functions listed above. Explain why the chosen metric matches the task and why the available results cannot establish production performance. Add your own documented experiment and be precise about what you implemented or changed. These are AI-assisted educational projects; filenames and synthetic scores are not evidence of client work.

Verified build results

project

"Leakage-Aware Demand Forecasting"

validation

[{"alpha": 0.1, "mean_rmse": 2.2639585262825848}, {"alpha": 10, "mean_rmse": 2.3550849455978207}, {"alpha": 100, "mean_rmse": 2.3788681417000563}]

selected alpha

0.1

test rmse

2.177684702825123

seasonal naive rmse

2.8036451695137243

forecast mode

"rolling one-step; observed prior test values allowed"

See results/metrics.json for all observations and TEST_RESULTS.txt for the executed tests. All datasets and replay responses shipped here are synthetic. Results can vary across seeds and numerical library versions.